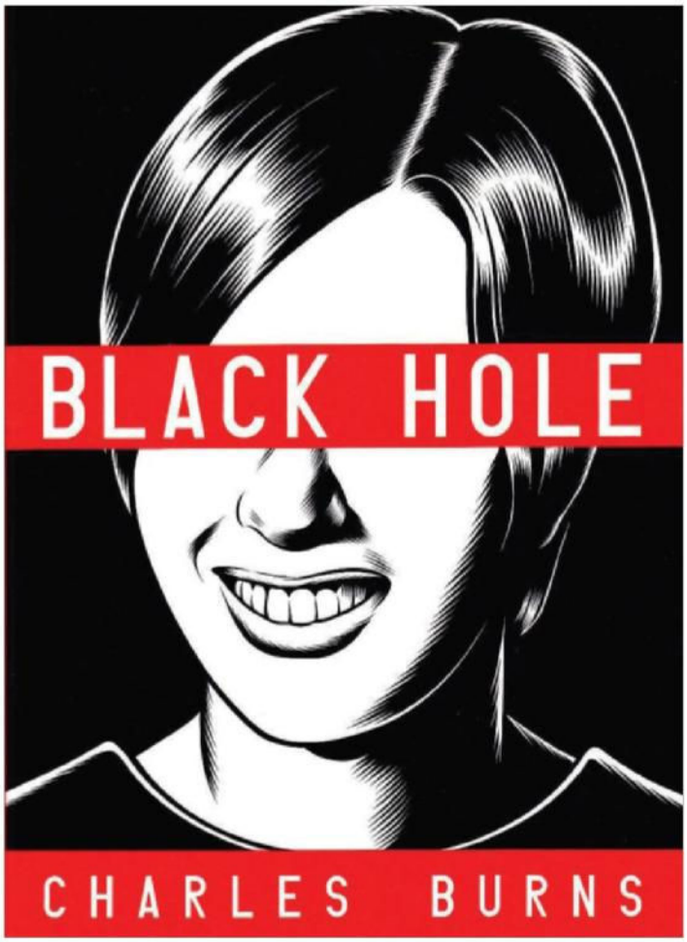


BLACK HOLE

Details **Originally published** Black Hole #1-12 (1995-2005) **Publisher** Fantagraphics **Writer** Charles Burns **Artist** Charles Burns **Collected in** Black Hole **Available digitally** List platforms, ie. Comixology, Marvel Unlimited

Black Hole is equally haunting as it is brilliant. Writer/illustrator Charles Burns transports the reader to seventies Seattle as a mysterious disease begins to sweep across the city, causing strange mutations amongst the local teenage population. Spread through sexual contact, the disease leaves highly visible and grotesque marks on some, while others are left less obviously scarred. If that isn't a metaphor for going through puberty, then we clearly remember our childhoods incorrectly.

But, then again, everything that happens at the dawn of adolescence can have profound and unknown effects on the teenage psyche. The way *Black Hole* delicately explores classic fears of adulthood with a wonderfully considered horror noir vibe is one of its greatest assets, but it's the way it crawls under your skin that will stick with you. *Black Hole* is an incredible work of literature; it has moments that will shock, disturb and confound you. It's an example of what makes this medium so great.



STARMAN: OMNIBUS VOL 1

Details **Originally published** Starman #0-16 (1994-2001) **Publisher** DC **Writer** James Robinson **Artist** Tony Harris **Collected in** Starman Omnibus **Available digitally** Comixology

Jack Knight is one of the sons of Ted Knight, the original Starman. His father is a scientist and former superhero, his older brother has taken up the mantle, and Jack... runs a vintage junk shop – until events conspire to put the most unlikely Knight in the role of family hero.



This is the sweetest book on the list, and certainly the one that hits home the most. Jack is an eminently relatable lead; a little directionless, but good-hearted and desperate to do the right thing. The way Robinson takes him through his hero's journey is as elegant as it is emotionally exhausting, and several issues in the run are deeply moving, beautifully written stuff. Rounded out by the unique and often astonishing artwork of Tony Harrison, this is a book that comes from a rich history, but has a personality all its own – just like Jack himself.

